

MINUTES OF MEETING HELD October 17th, 2025 OF GRADUATE AND PROFESSIONAL STUDENT COUNCIL, EXECUTIVE BOARD

A meeting of the Graduate and Professional Student Council (GPSC), Executive Board (EB) was convened on Friday, October 17th at 2:00 PM held at Espresso Art Cafe and on zoom.

1. Call to Order

Time meeting begins: 2:00 pm

Roll call: Mourad Abdennebi, Naama Levy, Travis Dean, Mehrdad Aghayari, Milad Hasankhani, Rishabh Bhattad, Roselyn Amamoo, Solange Quintana, Elham Chalebi

2. Call to Audience

The EB may not discuss items that are not on the agenda. Therefore, action taken as a result of public comment will be limited to directing staff to study the matter or scheduling the matter for consideration at a later date.

3. Review and Approve Meeting Minutes

The minutes from the previous meeting (October 6th, 2025) were reviewed and approved.

4. Officer Reports

- President:

- Thanked officers and representatives for their continued advocacy and feedback.
- Reported the university declined the Higher Education Compact but remains open to dialogue.
- Noted slow but positive progress on stipend increases, counseling fee elimination/access, and basic needs expansion.

- Executive Vice President:

- Expressed fatigue regarding compact discussions; no major operational updates.

- Administrative Vice President:

- Worked with the EB on the response to the compact decision and stand of GPSC on compact.
- Continued work on internal GPSC structure and organization, including the GPSC activity tracker for transparency.

- Treasurer:

- Working with Graduate College and new Admin Consultant (Katie) to



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clarify budget status.

- **Secretary:**

- Minutes from the last EB meeting have been finalized and uploaded to the Box folder for review.

- **Assembly Chair:**

- Visited and approved the new GC meeting location, confirming functional AV technology.
- Raised concern for having sensitive conversation in meetings with regards to safety, and suggested to use executive session for such discussions.

- **Director of Communications:**

- Maintained social media (Instagram, LinkedIn) and newsletter distribution and it is going great.
- Latest newsletter awaiting final approval.
- Initiated planning meetings for Student Showcase and Cap & Gown program (inventory, dry cleaning).
- Planning the GPSC's October social event.

- **Director of Grants & Funding:**

- Travel and PPG grant cycle closed Oct 16th; reviewers assigned on Oct 17th.
- The first review phase is expected to end Oct 24th.
- Appropriations Committee meeting to follow to review and set funding cutoffs.

- **Director of Policy:**

- The public policy change tracker is ready for distribution.
- Updated on Higher Education Compact status (other universities' decisions, UArizona pending).
- The Policy Committee discussed scenarios and future actions (funding campaigns, identifying affected students).
- Noted public comment period open for policy change affecting international student status duration.

5. New Business & Action Items

- **Recording General Council Meetings:** A discussion was held regarding whether to record the entirety of GC meetings, particularly the open discussion segments. Concerns were raised that constant recording might inhibit open and honest feedback from representatives. The idea of using a motion to go into executive session and pause recording during specific discussion periods was proposed. It was decided to bring this procedural question to the General Council for their input.



- **EB Retreat Ideas:** The purpose (team building, informal planning) was discussed. Suggestions included a social gathering at a restaurant or an outdoor activity like hiking, funded individually rather than by GPSC, noting retreats typically happen earlier in the term. The consensus was to plan an informal social event for the EB outside of official duties, requiring no formal vote.
- **ABOR Summary & Takeaways:** Elham summarized her attendance at the Sept 25th ABOR meeting: delivering public comment (funding, international student issues, campus safety/academic freedom) and providing a formal letter. Mourad added confirmation from the Student Regent that ABOR received the letter, noting ABOR's power and GPSC's active role. UArizona received approval for significant funding (\$30M infrastructure, \$50M sports). A decision on the Higher Education Compact was noted as possibly imminent.
- **MailChimp Budget Reallocation & Budget Review:** Travis proposed reallocating the ~\$3,000 MailChimp budget (as the listserv is effective), possibly towards increasing rep stipends. Rishabh proposed using funds for an AI chatbot/digital historian project and will develop a proposal. Data privacy concerns were raised for the AI tool. Solange inquired about the Cap & Gown dry cleaning budget (~\$2,000), suggesting it come from social/marketing funds. Milad noted retreat sign-in sheets are needed for catering justification. For the grant platform provider it was noted that the 3-year contract prevents switching grant platforms until after the next academic year. Milad will provide an updated budget spreadsheet.
- **Summer Transition and Elections Timeline:** Naama presented a document proposing improvements to EB onboarding/transition, citing past difficulties. The need for P-Card training and practical issues (PINs, policies) were discussed. EB members agreed to review Naama's document, add role-specific suggestions (with Box links), and revisit it at the next EB meeting.
- **Prioritization and Strategy / Activity Tracking Sheet:** Consolidation of tracker efforts into one document was agreed upon for transparency. The tracker will be finalized after upcoming GC votes and then shared with the GC. Defining project categories (Policy Statement, Event, Project, Tech) was discussed.
- **Student IRB Approval Issues:** An issue was raised concerning rejection from the Institutional Review Board (IRB) for research involving faculty perspectives on federal funding cuts, potentially due to perceived political sensitivity or confidentiality risks specific to UArizona faculty. Although eventually approval was received after revisions. Travis noted potential IRB concerns about confidentiality risks for studies involving campus employees and highlighted the confidentiality restrictions preventing GPSC from directly intervening in specific IRB cases. Mourad mentioned the Provost had also expressed concern. The agreed next steps are for EB members to look into the case, and then follow up with the IRB office to discuss the situation and potential systemic improvements.



- **Cap & Gown Rental Program – Addressing Non>Returns:** The issue of non-returned gowns (5-15 per cycle) was highlighted. Pursuing Bursar holds via CatCard integration (based on past work) was discussed, deemed feasible for Spring 2026 but unlikely for Dec 2025. Potential reduction of Fall commencements was noted. The EB informally agreed (majority favored, Mehrdad abstained) to pursue the Bursar hold solution. The need for volunteers was noted.
- **Planning & Agenda for General Council Meeting #4 (Oct 20th):** Key items for the upcoming GC meeting were confirmed: voting on 2 new reps, voting on 5 core goals/projects, formally noting the compact email vote. Agreed additions include an open discussion (potentially off-record) on rep engagement, Policy Committee report time, and presenting the Activity Tracker. Managing potential compact debate (time limits, off-record option) was discussed. Naama will share constituent concern survey results.
- **GPSC/ASUA Mixer (Oct 20th, 5-6 PM):** Details for the mixer with ASUA and administrators (location, attendees, purpose: networking, discuss "Gratitude Dinner") were confirmed. GPSC will not contribute funds (ASUA/Res Life providing snacks). Snacks for the subsequent GC meeting were confirmed.
- **Items Requiring Vote/Decision:**
 - **Donuts with GPSC:** This event idea was tabled. Priority was given to an October social at the GPSC house (backyard). An EB-only "pizza cleanup" at the house will be scheduled via Doodle poll.
 - **Pop-Up Pantry Relocation:** The EB unanimously agreed to relocate the pantry from the GPSC house to the Graduate Center for better accessibility (operational decision).
 - **Student Showcase Planning:** Discussed funding (\$15k received for awards vs. ~\$30k needed for organizing) and the existing planning committee. The EB voted unanimously to propose moving forward with Student Showcase planning at the next GC meeting for broader approval and involvement.

6. Motion to Adjourn

- Motion to adjourn the meeting by President:
 - The motion was seconded by Travis.
 - The meeting was adjourned at 3:27 pm.

Dated this 17th day of October 2025

Graduate and Professional Student Council Executive Board

Rishabh Bhattad, Secretary